

CONTENT TEAM REFERENCE

Social Content Specs — 2026 Production Guide

Facebook · Instagram · TikTok · LinkedIn · YouTube

How to use this guide

This is your production reference for every post we ship. For each platform you'll find the **media specs** (sizes, lengths, formats), **caption rules** (limits + where the hook must land), and **what the 2026 algorithm rewards** — so every asset is built to perform, not just to fill a slot.

> **Vertical-first, always.** 9:16 (1080×1920) is the default for video on every platform. The hook has to land in the **first 1–3 seconds** or the post dies. Front-load the hook *and* your main keyword before the caption cuts off at "...more."

The 5 rules that apply everywhere

1. **Hook in the first 1–3 seconds.** Watch-time and completion decide reach on every platform now.
2. **Front-load the caption.** Every platform truncates — put the hook and primary keyword in the first ~125 characters.
3. **3–5 hashtags, not 30.** Hashtags are de-emphasized in 2026. Use a few targeted ones; stuffing does nothing (or hurts).
4. **Write for search.** TikTok, Instagram, YouTube and LinkedIn are all search engines now. Keyword-rich captions, on-screen text, and alt text drive discovery as much as hashtags.
5. **Original content wins; reposting loses.** Recycled/duplicated posts get suppressed (Instagram openly penalizes 10+ reposts in 30 days). Disclose AI-generated media — undisclosed AI gets down-ranked.

Facebook

Media sizes

Use	Size	Ratio
Feed image (best mobile reach)	1080 × 1350	4:5
Feed square	1080 × 1080	1:1
Reels / Stories	1080 × 1920	9:16

- **Reels:** 9:16, 1080×1920, **3–90 seconds**, MP4. Burn captions into the video (most people scroll with sound off).
- **Feed video:** 16:9, 1:1, or 4:5.

Captions: keep it short — **40–80 characters gets the most reach**. Only the first ~125 characters show before "See more." Use **1–3 hashtags** max. Don't put links in the post body (it cuts reach) — **put the link in the first comment**.

What wins in 2026: Reels and video dominate (video is shared ~12× more than anything else). **Shares and saves matter more than likes**. Aim for 15–30s Reels. Post ~4–5×/week — more isn't better. Best days: Tue/Wed/Thu.

Instagram

Media sizes

- **Feed image: 4:5 — 1080 × 1350** is the default now. (Square is no longer optimal.)
- **Reels / Stories:** 9:16, 1080×1920. Keep key elements inside the center (top/bottom get covered by UI).
- **Reels:** up to **3 minutes**. Regular feed video posts as a Reel now.

Captions: up to 2,200 characters; hook in the first ~125. Use **3–5 hashtags**. Captions aren't clickable — drive to **link in bio** or a **Stories link sticker**. Always fill in **alt text** (helps search + accessibility).

What wins in 2026: watch time is the #1 signal, then **DM shares ("sends")**, then likes. **Design posts people want to send to a friend** — that's what reaches new audiences. Reels for reach; carousels for saves and dwell time. Keep content original — reposts get you excluded from recommendations.

TikTok

Media specs

- **9:16, 1080 × 1920**, MP4 or MOV.
- Length: **3 seconds minimum**, up to 10 min (in-app) / 60 min (upload) — but **15–30 seconds performs best**.
- Photo carousels: 2–10 images, 1080×1920.
- Keep key elements centered (edges get covered by the UI).

Captions: up to 4,000 characters now — TikTok turned captions into an SEO tool, so **pack in keywords**. Only ~80–150 characters show before "...more," so front-load the hook. **3–5 hashtags**. Optimal length ~150–300 characters.

What wins in 2026: completion rate — getting people to watch to the end. **~70% completion triggers the viral push, 80%+ is strong**. Hook in the first 1–2 seconds. Post **3–5×/week**. Ride trending audio while it's relevant. **TikTok is a search engine** (84% of searches are people exploring) — put keywords in your caption, on-screen text, and voiceover.

LinkedIn

Media specs

- **Images:** 1200×627 (landscape), 1080×1080 (square), or **1080×1350 (portrait — best on mobile)**.
- **Document "carousels":** upload a PDF that swipes like slides — 1080×1080 or 1080×1350, **5–10 slides** is the sweet spot. (These are the single best-performing format.)
- **Video:** 3 seconds–10 min; 1:1, 16:9, or 9:16.

Captions: up to 3,000 characters; optimal ~150–250 words. The "See more" cut-off is brutal — **~140 characters on mobile** — so the hook has to land there. Use **3–5 hashtags**.

What wins in 2026: dwell time (a 60-second read is worth ~13× a 3-second scroll) and **comments** (worth far more than likes). Lead with **knowledge and expertise** — educational beats promotional. ⚠️ **Outbound links cut reach ~60%, and the old "link in first comment" trick is now penalized too** — deliver the value natively and link only as a secondary step. Reply to comments fast; the first hour decides everything. Post 2–5×/week.

YouTube

Media specs

- **Shorts:** 9:16, **up to 3 minutes**, 1080×1920. (Must be vertical and ≤3 min to land on the Shorts shelf.)
- **Long-form:** 16:9, 1920×1080 or higher.
- **Thumbnail:** 1280×720, under 2 MB. This is your single biggest click driver — invest in it.

Text: Title up to 100 characters (keyword in the first ~60). Description up to 5,000 characters — put the keyword in the first line. `#Shorts` is no longer required.

What wins in 2026: viewer satisfaction now matters more than raw watch time (YouTube measures whether people come back and keep watching). Shorts and long-form are ranked separately — for **Shorts**, the swipe-vs-watch decision in the first 1–3 seconds + replays + shares; for **long-form**, retention and click-through (thumbnail + title). Be consistent. Disclosed AI content is fine; undisclosed AI gets down-ranked.

Quick reference

Platform	Video ratio	Best video length	Caption hook by	Hashtags	The #1 thing that wins
Facebook	9:16 (Reels)	15–30s	~125 chars	1–3	Shares & saves
Instagram	9:16	15–30s (≤3 min)	~125 chars	3–5	DM shares ("sends")
TikTok	9:16	15–30s	~80–150 chars	3–5	Completion rate (~70%+)
LinkedIn	1:1 / 9:16	≤60s	~140 chars	3–5	Dwell time + comments
YouTube	9:16 (Shorts) / 16:9	Shorts ≤3 min	Title first 60 chars	—	Thumbnail CTR + retention